

FAMILY TOGETHERNESS WEEK OF PRAYER | SEPTEMBER 1-7, 2024

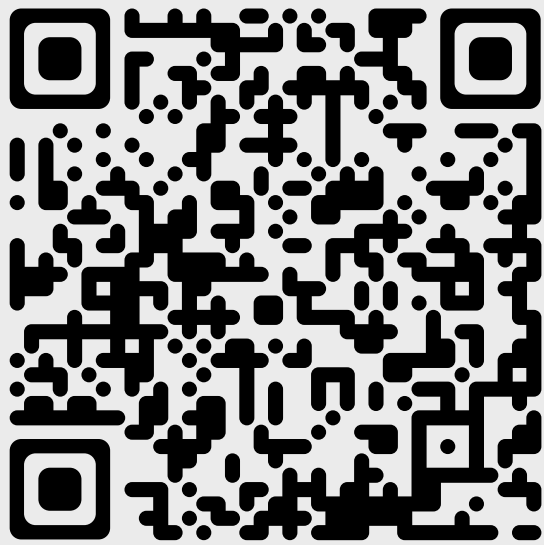
GROWING HEARTS OF
WELCOME
UNDERSTANDING DIVERSE FAMILIES



Adventist®
Family Ministries

2024
RESOURCE
BOOK

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I WILL GO WITH MY FAMILY:

UNDERSTANDING DIVERSE FAMILIES

GROWING HEARTS OF WELCOME

UNDERSTANDING DIVERSE FAMILIES

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A photograph of a light-colored, textured doormat with a dark border, placed on a tiled floor. The text "UNDERSTANDING DIVERSE FAMILIES" is printed in large, bold, black capital letters across the center of the mat. To the left of the mat, a portion of a potted plant with green leaves is visible. The background is a light-colored tiled floor with a geometric pattern. A blue diagonal graphic element is present on the right side of the image.

UNDERSTANDING DIVERSE FAMILIES

INTRODUCTION

In cultures around the world there are families with unique challenges that make them different than what may be considered the norm, especially at a time when mass migration for various reasons—war, gang violence, political and religious

repression, lack of opportunities, and poverty—is in process in many parts of our planet today. Also, there are families with members who are experiencing neurodiversity, and a host of other physical, emotional and psycho-social

challenges,
in addition to
racial, ethnic, nationality
and language differences. As
Christians, it is essential to approach
this reality with love, compassion, and
understanding, guided by the teachings
of Jesus Christ. Two key passages from
the Bible, John 13:35 and Matthew 25:40,
provide a foundation for embracing and
supporting diverse families within our
communities.

In John 13:35, Jesus declares, *“By this
all will know that you are My disciples,
if you have love for one another.”* This
verse emphasizes the importance of
demonstrating love and acceptance
towards others, regardless of what their

family
looks like,
sounds like, or is
challenged by. As followers of
Christ, we are called to extend love
and support to all families.

To be sure, Matthew 25:40 states, *“And
the King will answer and say to them,
‘Assuredly, I say to you, inasmuch as
you did it to one of the least of these My
brethren, you did it to Me.’”* This passage
highlights the significance of caring for and
serving those who may be marginalized or
vulnerable in communities where we live
and work. By offering support, resources,
and understanding to diverse families, we
are ultimately serving Christ and fulfilling
the great commandment (Matt. 22:39).

To effectively minister to diverse families, it is crucial to approach them with an open mind and a willingness to listen and learn. By setting aside preconceived notions and judgments—even when their practices are not compatible with what we believe to be the truth—we can better appreciate the unique challenges and strengths of each family unit. Through this awareness, we can provide tailored support and guidance, helping families to thrive and grow in their faith.

As Christians, we are called to extend love, compassion, and acceptance to all families, regardless of how different they might be to us. By embracing the teachings of John 13:35 and Matthew 25:40, we can create a welcoming and supportive environment that celebrates the diversity of families within our communities, ultimately

reflecting the love of Christ to the world. Our prayer is that this devotional resource will help lead your family to a place of greater understanding, kindness, empathy, and compassion. That by so doing, you will in essence become the hands, feet, and heart of God to every family in need, and help hasten the coming of Jesus Christ.

Remain encouraged and faithful.



Adventist®
Family Ministries

Willie and Elaine Oliver, Directors
Seventh-day Adventist Church
World Headquarters



If you would like to expand your knowledge on understanding diverse families from a biblical perspective, please get our free 2024 Resource Book.

Available now in Bahasa Malaysia, Chinese, English, French, Italian, Portuguese, Russian, and Spanish.

Visit: family.adventist.org/2024RB

A note from the Principal Contributor

KAREN HOLFORD



This year, the focus of the week is on *Understanding Diverse Families*. We aim to help our family connect with Jesus and emulate how He approached others, regardless of their circumstances. We will be invited to welcome everyone, opening our minds to see them as Jesus would. By observing how Jesus interacted with the rich and the poor, men and women, children and adults, people with disabilities, and individuals from various cultures, we will learn to keep *Growing Hearts of Welcome*. Jesus' example teaches us to embrace diversity and foster a spirit of love and acceptance.

Karen Holford is the Family, Children's and Women's Ministries Director for the Trans-European Division. She has a professional background in occupational therapy and master's degrees in psychology, Family Therapy and Christian Leadership. She is married to Pastor Bernie Holford, and they live in England. They have three adult children and three grandchildren. She loves to write, walk in English forests, and share God's love.

HOW TO WELCOME
**FAMILY
WORSHIP**
INTO YOUR FAMILY DAILY LIFE?

WHY?

WHY FAMILY WORSHIP?

- It teaches our children and families to worship God
- Places God at the center of our homes
- Bonds our families together
- Protects our children and families
- Establishes spiritual values

WHAT?

WHAT FAMILY WORSHIP **IS**:

- Interactive
- Shared leadership
- Brief and engaging

WHAT FAMILY WORSHIP **IS NOT**:

- A lecture, sermon, or coercive activity
- Time for discipline or punishment
- Entertainment

HOW?

Worship is a time when we give adoration and praise to God. With reverence, humility, and gratitude, we make our requests to him. In the Old Testament, animals were sacrificed on the altars. **Today, we need only a sacrifice of time and self.** When we add the word family to worship, we come together to worship God as a family.

Parents especially get an **opportunity to disciple their children and teach them how to worship God.** Together, we take the time to express honor and respect to God and acknowledge Him as Lord and Savior of our lives and our home. This experience bonds us to one another and draws us closer to God.

Every family can decide how their family worship time looks and what tools they will include. It may consist of reading the bible, singing a song, and praying together as a family. But there are many ways to have family worship as many as there are families. Every family is unique, so you can custom build your *family altar* just for your family. **The only thing that remains the same is that we should turn our focus toward God,** the Creator and Sustainer of humankind.

“In every family there should be a fixed time for morning and evening worship. How appropriate it is for parents to gather their children about them before the fast is broken, to thank the heavenly Father for His protection during the night, and...when evening comes, to gather once more before Him and thank Him for the blessings of the day past.”

Ellen G. White, *Child Guidance*, p. 520

REMEMBER:

Your family worship may not be perfect, and that's okay. Pray to God and keep doing your best; He is with you.

“There is no reason why [family worship] should not be the most interesting and enjoyable exercise of the home life, and God is dishonored when it is made dry and irksome. Let the seasons of family worship be short and spirited.”

Ellen G. White, *Child Guidance*, p. 521

WITH GODS HELP, WELCOME CHRIST'S LOVE INTO YOUR FAMILY

God created us in His own image, and we are proof of God's love for diversity. Every member of your family is called to reflect Jesus, and the best way to do this is by following His actions. Jesus always welcomed everyone and had words of compassion, encouragement, and understanding for them.

Diversity exists both outside and inside your family, encompassing men and

women, adults and children, those with special needs, and people from different cultural backgrounds. Our actions will demonstrate how we embrace Jesus' love for others.

This week, you and your family are called to WELCOME Christ's love for everyone. Decide to open your hearts and minds, welcoming the diversity that surrounds you. By doing so, you will embody the inclusive and compassionate spirit of Jesus.

HOW TO USE THIS RESOURCE

STEPS TO WELCOME UNDERSTANDING

BIBLE VERSE

A Bible verse with a simple, creative activity to help you memorize it and experience it in a practical way

FOUNDATION

DEVOTIONAL

A short devotional story designed for the whole family

CORE MESSAGE

ACTIVITIES

Several simple activities to help you practice the positive emotions in your family life.

REINFORCING

INTRODUCTION

An introduction to the theme of the day and why it is good for us

SETTING THE MOOD

PRAYER

Pray together—where everyone can share their heart's desire.

COMMUNION

IN A HURRY? TRY THE SNAPSHOT! SECTION AT THE END OF EVERY DAY.